Lesson 36

THE BEMA SEAT OF CHRIST

Aim: To teach the believers the biblical teaching of the second phase of the second coming of Christ, the Bema Judgement.

Introduction: "We are to wait for the coming of Christ with patience. We are to watch with anticipation. We are to work with Zeal. We are to prepare with urgency. Scripture says Christ is coming when you're least expecting him. Coming as a thief. He said, 'Be prepared. Get Ready. Prepare to meet thy God. Are you prepared?'" Dr. Billy Graham Here we come to the second phase of the second coming of Christ, the Bema judgement. In this lesson we will begin to see one the glorious activity of Christ at His advent. We will answer some of the tough questions on what will happen to the saints after they will be judged based on their performance while we are in this earth.

What is the Judgment Seat of Christ / Bema Seat of Christ?

Romans 14:10-12 says, "For we will all stand before God's judgment seat…so then, each of us will give an account of himself to God."

Romans 14:10-12 10You, then, why do you judge your brother or sister? Or why do you treat them with contempt? For we will all stand before God's judgment seat. 11It is written: "'As surely as I live,' says the Lord, 'every knee will bow before me; every tongue will acknowledge God.'"12So then, each of us will give an account of ourselves to God. 2 Corinthians 5:10 tells us, *"For we must all appear before the judgment seat of Christ, that each one may receive what is due him for the things done while in the body, whether good or bad."*

In the context, it is clear that both scriptures are referring to Christians, not unbelievers. The judgment seat of Christ, therefore, involves believers giving an account of their lives to Christ. The judgment seat of Christ does not determine salvation; that was determined by Christ's sacrifice on our behalf (1 John 2:2) and our faith in Him (John 3:16). All of our sins are forgiven, and we will never be condemned for them (Romans 8:1). We should not look at the judgment seat of Christ as God judging our sins, but rather as God rewarding us for our lives. Yes, as the Bible says, we will have to give

an account of ourselves. Part of this is surely answering for the sins we committed. However, that is not going to be the primary focus of the judgment seat of Christ.

1 John 2:2-2 He is the atoning sacrifice for our sins, and not only for ours but also for the sins of the whole world.

Romans 8:1-8 Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus,

At the judgment seat of Christ, believers are rewarded based on how faithfully they served Christ (1 Corinthians 9:4-27; 2 Timothy 2:5). Some of the things we might be judged on are how well we obeyed the Great Commission (Matthew 28:18-20), how victorious we were over sin (Romans 6:1-4), and how well we controlled our tongues (James 3:1-9). The Bible speaks of believers receiving crowns for different things based on how faithfully they served Christ (1 Corinthians 9:4-27; 2 Timothy 2:5). The various crowns are described in 2 Timothy 2:5, 2 Timothy 4:8, James 1:12, 1 Peter 5:4, and Revelation 2:10. James 1:12 is a good summary of how we should think about the judgment seat of Christ: “Blessed is the man who perseveres under trial, because when he has stood the test, he will receive the crown of life that God has promised to those who love him.”

2 Timothy 2:5-5 similarly, anyone who competes as an athlete does not receive the victor's crown except by competing according to the rules.

Matthew 28:18-20 18Then Jesus came to them and said, "All authority in heaven and on earth has been given to me. 19Therefore go and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, 20and teaching them to obey everything I have commanded you. And surely I am with you always, to the very end of the age."

Romans 6:1-4-6 what shall we say, then? Shall we go on sinning so that grace may increase? 2 By no means! We are those who have died to sin; how can we live in it any longer? 3Or don't you know that all of us who were baptized into Christ Jesus were baptized into his death? 4We were therefore buried with him through baptism into death in order that, just as Christ was raised from the dead through the glory of the Father, we too may live a new life.

2 Timothy 4:8 8Now there is in store for me the crown of righteousness, which the Lord, the righteous Judge, will award to me on that day—and not only to me, but also to all who have longed for his appearing.

James 1:12 12Blessed is the one who perseveres under trial because, having stood the test, that person will receive

the crown of life that the Lord has promised to those who love him.

1 Peter 5:4 4And when the Chief Shepherd appears, you will receive the crown of glory that will never fade away.

Revelation 2:10 10Do not be afraid of what you are about to suffer. I tell you, the devil will put some of you in prison to test you, and you will suffer persecution for ten days. Be faithful, even to the point of death, and I will give you life as your victor's crown.

What are the five heavenly crowns that believers can receive in Heaven?

There are five heavenly crowns mentioned in the New Testament that will be awarded to believers. They are the imperishable crown, the crown of rejoicing, the crown of righteousness, the crown of glory, and the crown of life.

The Greek word translated "crown" is stephanos (the source for the name Stephen the martyr) and means "a badge of royalty, a prize in the public games or a symbol of honor generally." Used during the ancient Greek games, it referred to a wreath or garland of leaves placed on a victor's head as a reward for winning an athletic contest.

As such, this word is used figuratively in the New Testament of the rewards of heaven God promises t hose who are faithful.

Paul's passage in 1 Corinthians 9:24-25 best defines for us how these crowns are awarded.

1. The Imperishable Crown– (1 Corinthians 9:24-25) *"Do you not know that those who run in a race all run, but one receives the prize? Run in such a way that you may obtain it. And everyone who competes for the prize is temperate [disciplined] in all things. Now they do it to obtain a perishable crown, but we for an imperishable crown" (NKJV). All things on this earth are subject to decay and will perish. Jesus urges us to not store our treasures on earth "where moth and rust destroy, and where thieves break in and steal" (Matthew 6:19).*

This is analogous to what Paul was saying about that wreath of leaves that was soon to turn brittle and fall apart. But not so the heavenly crown; faithful endurance wins a heavenly reward which is "an inheritance incorruptible and undefiled and that does not fade away, reserved in heaven for you" (1 Peter 1:3-5). 2)

2. The Crown of Rejoicing– (1 Thessalonians 2:19) *"For what is our hope, or joy, or crown of rejoicing? Is it not even you in the presence of our Lord Jesus Christ at His coming?"*

   The apostle Paul tells us in Philippians 4:4 to *"rejoice always in the Lord"* for all the bountiful blessings our gracious God has showered upon us. As Christians we have more in this life to rejoice about than anyone else. Luke tells us there is rejoicing even now in heaven (Luke 15:7). The crown of rejoicing will be our reward where *"God will wipe away every tear . . . there shall be no more death, nor sorrow, nor crying. There shall be no more pain, for the former things have passed away" (Revelation 21:4).*

3. The Crown of Righteousness– (2 Timothy 4:8) *"Finally, there is laid up for me the crown of righteousness, which the Lord, the righteous Judge, will give to me on that Day, and not to me only but also to all who have loved His appearing."*

   We inherit this crown through the righteousness of Christ which is what gives us a right to it, and without which it cannot be obtained. Because it is obtained and possessed in a righteous way, and not by force and deceit as earthly crowns sometimes are, it

is an everlasting crown, promised to all who love the Lord and eagerly wait for His return. Through our enduring the discouragements, persecutions, sufferings, or even death, we know assuredly our reward is with Christ in eternity (Philippians 3:20). This crown is not for those who depend upon their own sense of righteousness or of their own works. Such an attitude breeds only arrogance and pride, not a longing, a fervent desire to be with the Lord.

4. The Crown of Glory– (1 Peter 5:4) *"And when the Chief Shepherd appears, you will receive the crown of glory that does not fade away."*

Though Peter is addressing the elders, we must also remember that the crown will be awarded to all those who long for or love His appearing. This word "glory" is an interesting word referring to the very nature of God and His actions. It entails His great splendor and brightness. Recall Stephen who, while being stoned to death, was able to look into the heavens and see the glory of God (Acts 7:55-56). This word also means that the praise and honor we bestow to God alone is due Him because of who He is (Isaiah 42:8, 48:11; Galatians 1:5). It also recognizes that believers are incredibly blessed to enter into the

kingdom, into the very likeness of Christ Himself. For as Paul so eloquently put it, *"For I consider that the sufferings of this present time are not worthy to be compared with the glory which shall be revealed in us" (Romans 8:18 NKJV).*

5. The Crown of Life– (Revelation 2:10) *"Do not fear any of those things which you are about to suffer. Indeed, the devil is about to throw some of you into prison, that you may be tested, and you will have tribulation ten days. Be faithful until death, and I will give you the crown of life."*

This crown is for all believers, but is especially dear to those who endure sufferings, who bravely confront persecution for Jesus, even to the point of death. In Scripture the word "life" is often used to show a relationship that is right with God. It was Jesus who said, "I have come that they may have life and that they may have it more abundantly" (John 10:10). Just as things such as air, food, and water are vital for our physical lives, Jesus provides us what is required for our spiritual lives. He is the One who provides "living water." He is the "bread of life" (John 4:10, 6:35). We know that our earthly lives will end. But we have the amazing promise that comes only to

those who come to God through Jesus: “And this is the promise that He has promised us—eternal life” (1 John 2:25).

James tells us that this crown of life is for all those who love God (James 1:12). The question then is how do we demonstrate our love for God? The apostle John answers this for us: “For this is the love of God, that we keep His commandments. And His commandments are not burdensome” (1 John 5:3). As His children we must keep His commandments, obeying Him, always remaining faithful. So, as we endure the inevitable trials, pains, heartaches, and tribulations—as long as we live—may we ever move forward, always “looking unto Jesus, the author and finisher of our faith” (Hebrews 12:2) and receive the crown of life that awaits us.

HOW CAN I BE PREPARED TO MEET THE BEMA?

- By constant communion with my Savior Jesus Christ.
- By much self-examination.
- By constant confession of my sins.
- By much prayer and meditation the Word of God. By constant attention to the will of the Holy Spirit.

Conclusion

The believer's judgement before the judgement Seat of Christ is not a judgement of condemnation, but the determining the believer's awards. To the Christian the Bema should no terrors, it ought to the best day he has ever had. It will be his crowning day. Readings and supplements: Foundations of Pentecostal Theology One Hundred Bible lessons Got Questions.Org